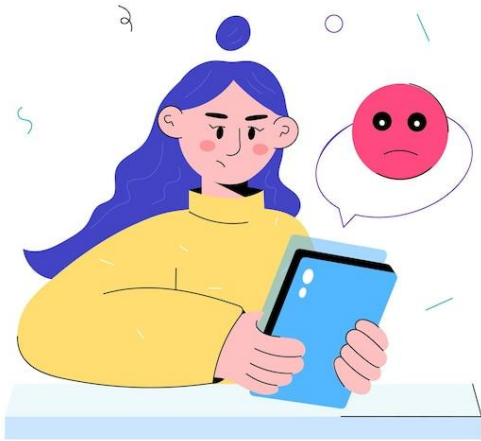


LECTURE 6

Writing Persuasive & Negative Message



Negative Message

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Learning Objectives:

1. The three-step process for negative message
2. High Standards of Ethics and Etiquette
3. Sending Negative Organizational News
4. Sending Negative Employment Messages
5. Developing a persuasive business message

Three-Step Process for Negative Messages

- Delivering negative information is rarely easy and never enjoyable, but with some helpful guidelines, you can craft messages that minimize negative reactions.

The three-step process includes:

1. Plan the message
2. Write the message
3. Complete the message

Three-Step Process for Negative Messages

The three-step process includes:

1. **Plan the message**

- When planning messages that will convey negative news, remember that your **audience doesn't want to hear what you have to say**. To minimize the damage to business relationships and to encourage the acceptance of your message, plan carefully. With a **clear purpose** and **your audience's needs in mind**, gather the information your audience will need in order to understand and accept your message.
- **Selecting the right medium is critical**. For instance, experts advise that bad news for employees always be delivered in person whenever possible, both to show respect for the employees and to give them an opportunity to ask questions. Of course, delivering bad news is never easy, and an increasing number of managers appear to be using e-mail and other electronic media to convey negative messages to employees.

Three-Step Process for Negative Messages

The three-step process includes:

1. **Plan the message**

- Finally, the organization of negative messages requires particular care. One of the most critical planning decisions is choosing the **best approach**.
- A negative message using the direct approach opens with the bad news, proceeds to the reasons for the situation or the decision, and ends with a positive statement aimed at maintaining a good relationship with the audience.
- In contrast, the indirect approach opens with the reasons behind the bad news before presenting the bad news itself.

Three-Step Process for Negative Messages

The three-step process includes:

2. Write the message

- By writing clearly and sensitively, you can take some of the sting out of bad news and help your reader accept the decision and move on.
- If your credibility hasn't already been established with an audience, clarify your qualifications so message recipients won't question your authority or ability.
- When you use language that conveys respect and avoids an accusing tone, you protect your audience's pride. This kind of communication **etiquette is always important**, but it demands special care with negative messages. Moreover, you can ease the sense of disappointment by using positive words rather than negative, counterproductive ones.

Three-Step Process for Negative Messages

The three-step process includes:

3. **Complete the message**

- The need for careful attention to detail continues as you complete your message.
- **Revise** your content to make sure everything is clear, complete, and concise—even small flaws can be magnified in readers' minds as they react to your negative news.
- Produce clean, professional documents, and proofread carefully to eliminate mistakes.
- Finally, be sure to deliver messages promptly; withholding or delaying bad news can be unethical and even illegal.

High Standards of Ethics and Etiquette



High Standards of Ethics and Etiquette

- All business **messages demand attention to ethics and etiquette**, of course, but these considerations **especially important when you are delivering bad news**—for several reasons.
- First, a variety of laws and regulations dictate the content and delivery of many business messages with potentially negative content, such as the release of financial information by a public company.
- Second, negative messages can have a significant effect on the lives of those receiving them. Even if the news is conveyed legally and conscientiously, good ethical practice demands that these situations be approached with care and sensitivity.
- Third, emotions often run high when negative messages are involved, for both the sender and the receiver. Senders need to not only manage their own emotions but also consider the emotional state of their audiences.

High Standards of Ethics and Etiquette

Legal Challenges:

- The challenge of sending—and receiving—**negative messages fosters a tendency to delay, downplay, or distort the bad news.**
- However, **doing so may be unethical, if not illegal.** In recent years, companies have been sued by shareholders, consumers, employees, and government regulators for allegedly withholding or delaying negative information in such areas as company finances, environmental hazards, and product safety.
- In many of these cases, the problem was slow, incomplete, or inaccurate communication between the company and external stakeholders.
- In others, problems stemmed from a reluctance to send or receive negative news within the organization.
- **News regarding corporate finances, environmental hazards or product safety issues.**

High Standards of Ethics and Etiquette

Corporate Effetcs:

- Effectively sharing bad news within an organization requires a commitment from everyone involved.
- **Employees must commit** to sending negative messages when necessary and to doing so in a timely fashion, even when that is unpleasant or difficult.
- Conversely, **managers must commit** to maintaining open communication channels, truly listening when employees have negative information to share, and not punishing employees who deliver bad news.

High Standards of Ethics and Etiquette

Manage the message:

- Keep in mind that negative messages can have a lasting impact on the people who receive them and the people who send them.
- **As a communicator, you have a responsibility to minimize the negative impact of your negative messages through careful planning and objective writing.**
- Focus on the actions or conditions that led to the negative news, rather than personal shortcomings or character issues.
- Develop a reputation as a professional who can handle the toughest situations with dignity.

Sending Negative Organizational News



Sending Negative Organizational News

- From time to time, managers must **share negative information with the public** at large and sometimes respond to negative information as well.
- Most of these scenarios have unique challenges that must be addressed on a case-by-case basis, but the general advice offered in this section applies to all of them.
- One key difference among all these messages is whether you have time to plan the announcement.
- **The following slides cover negative organizational news under normal circumstances and during emergencies.**

Normal Circumstances

Businesses must convey a range of negative messages regarding their ongoing operations. As you plan such messages, be sure to consider your audiences and their unique needs:

- **Match your approach to the situation.** A modest price increase won't shock most customers, so the direct approach is fine. However, canceling a product that people count on is another matter, so the indirect approach might be better.
- **Give each audience enough time to react as needed.** Customers and employees need sufficient time to adjust to the effects of the negative news.
- **Give yourself enough time to plan and manage a response.** Chances are you're going to be hit with complaints or questions after you make your announcement, so make sure you're ready with answers and additional follow-up information.
- **Look for positive angles but don't exude false optimism.** If eliminating a seldom-used employee benefit means employees will save money, by all means promote that positive angle. On the other hand, laying off 10,000 people does not give them "an opportunity to explore new horizons." Instead, it's a traumatic event.
- **Seek expert advice if you're not sure.** Many significant negative announcements have important technical, financial, or legal elements that require the expertise of lawyers, accountants, or other specialists.

Responding to Rumors

Responding to rumors and countering negative information requires an ongoing effort and case-by-case decisions about which messages require a response. Follow these four steps:

- **Engage early, engage often.** Perhaps the most important step in responding to negative information has to be done before the negative information appears, and that is to engage with communities of stakeholders as a long-term strategy.
- **Monitor the conversation.** If people are interested in what your company does, chances are they are blogging, tweeting, podcasting, posting videos, writing on Facebook walls, and otherwise sharing their opinions. Listen to what people are saying.
- **Evaluate negative messages.** When you encounter negative messages, resist the urge to fire back immediately. Instead, evaluate the source, the tone, and the content of the message and then choose a response that fits the situation.
- **Respond appropriately.** After you have assessed a negative message, take the appropriate response based on an overall public relations plan.

Whatever you do, don't assume that a positive reputation doesn't need to be diligently guarded and defended. Everybody has a voice now, and some of those voices don't care to play by the rules of ethical communication.

Sending Negative Employment Messages



Sending Negative Employment News

- All managers must **convey bad news about individual employees from time to time.**
- You can use the direct approach when writing to job applicants or when sending a negative reference to a prospective employer.
- But **it's best to use the indirect approach when giving negative performance reviews to employees;** they will most certainly be emotionally involved.
- In addition, choose the media for these messages with care.
- Written messages let you control the message and avoid personal confrontations, but one-on-one conversations are more sensitive and promote the interaction often needed to confront problems and discuss solutions.

Sending Negative Employment News

The following situation involves sending negative messages to the employees:

- 1. Refusing Requests for Employee References and Recommendation Letters:** Many former employers still refuse to write recommendation letters, specially for people whose job performance has been unsatisfactory. When sending refusals to prospective employers, your message may be brief and direct. On the other hand, any refusal to an applicant's direct request for a recommendation may seem to be a personal slight and a threat to the applicant's future. Diplomacy and preparation help readers accept your refusal.
- 2. Refusing Social Networking Recommendation Requests:** Making recommendations in a social media environment is more complicated than with a traditional recommendation letter because the endorsements you give become part of your online profile.

Sending Negative Employment News

The following situation involves sending negative messages to the employees:

3. **Giving Negative Performance Reviews:** Managers will encounter situations in which an employee's performance has not met expectations. When you need to give a negative performance review, use these guidelines:
 - **Document performance problems.** As you provide feedback throughout the year, keep a written record of performance issues. You will need this data in order to write an effective appraisal and to support any decisions that need to be made about pay, promotions, or termination.
 - **Evaluate all employees consistently.** Consistency is not only fair, but it also helps protect the company from claims of discriminatory practices.
 - **Write in a calm, objective voice.** Maintain a professional tone in your writing.
 - **Focus on opportunities for improvement.** As you document performance problems, identify specific steps the employee can take to correct them.
 - **Keep job descriptions up to date.** Performance evaluations should be based on the criteria listed in an employee's job description. However, if a job evolves over time in response to changes in the business, the employees' current activities may longer match an outdated job description.

Sending Negative Employment News

The following situation involves sending negative messages to the employees:

4. **Terminating Employment:** If an employee's performance cannot be brought up to company standards or if other factors cause a reduction in the workforce, a company often has no choice but to terminate employment. **Termination messages should always be written with input from the company's legal staff**, but here are some general writing guidelines to bear in mind:
 - Clearly present the reasons for this action, whether it is the employee's performance or a business decision unrelated to specific employees.
 - Make sure the reasons are presented in a way that cannot be construed as unfair or discriminatory.
 - Follow company policy and any relevant legal guidelines to the letter.
 - Avoid personal attacks or insults of any kind.
 - Ask another manager to review the letter before issuing it. An objective reviewer might spot troublesome wording or faulty reasoning.
 - Deliver the termination letter in person if at all possible. Arrange a meeting that will ensure privacy and freedom from interruptions.

Sending Negative Employment News

The following situation involves sending negative messages to the employees:

- 5. Rejecting Job Applications:** Although rejections are routine communications, they are difficult to write because saying "no" is never easy, and recipients are emotionally invested in the decision. The safest strategy is a minimal approach that includes the following elements:
- Personalize the message by using the recipient's name.
 - Open with a courteous expression of appreciation for being considered.
 - Convey the negative news politely and concisely.
 - Avoid explaining why an applicant was rejected or why other applicants were chosen.
 - Don't state or imply that the application will be reviewed at a later date.
 - Close with positive wishes for the applicant's career success.

Developing a persuasive business message



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Developing a persuasive business message

Effective persuasion involves four effective strategies:

1. **Framing your argument:** One of the best known is the **AIDA model**, which organizes messages into four phases
 - **Attention.** Your first objective is to encourage your audience to want to hear about your problem, idea, or new product—whatever your main idea is. Be sure to find some common ground on which to build your case.
 - **Interest.** Provide additional details that prompt audience members to imagine how the solution might benefit them.
 - **Desire.** Help audience members embrace your idea by explaining how the change will benefit them and answering potential objections.
 - **Action.** Suggest the specific action you want your audience to take. Include a deadline, when applicable.

Developing a persuasive business message

Effective persuasion involves four effective strategies:

2. **Balancing emotional and logical appeals:**

~ In general, persuasive business messages **rely more heavily on logical than on emotional appeals** because the main idea is usually to save money, increase quality, or improve some other practical, measurable aspect of business.

~ To find the **optimum balance**, consider four factors:

- (1) the actions you hope to motivate,
- (2) your readers' expectations,
- (3) the degree of resistance you need to overcome, and
- (4) your position in the formal and informal power structure of the organization.

Developing a persuasive business message

Effective persuasion involves four effective strategies:

3. **Reinforcing your position:**

~ Next, **examine your language**. For example, if your company is in serious financial trouble, talking about fighting for survival is a more powerful emotional appeal than talking about ensuring continued operations. As with any other powerful tool, though, use vivid language and abstractions carefully and honestly.

~ In addition to examining individual word choices, **consider using metaphors and other figures of speech**. For example, If you want to describe a quality-control system as being designed to detect every possible product flaw, you might call it a “spider web” to imply that it catches everything that comes its way.

~ Similarly, **anecdotes (brief stories)** can help your audience grasp the meaning and importance of your arguments. Instead of just listing the number of times the old laptop computers in your department have failed, you could describe how you lost a sale when your computer broke down during a critical sales presentation.

Developing a persuasive business message

Effective persuasion involves four effective strategies:

4. **Anticipating Objections:**

- ~ Even the most compelling ideas and proposals can be expected to encounter some initial resistance.
- ~ The **best way to deal with audience resistance is to anticipate as many objections as you can and address them** in your message before your audience can even bring them up.
- ~ For instance, if you know that your proposal to switch to lower-cost materials will raise concerns about product quality, address this issue head-on in your message. If you wait until people raise the concern after reading your message, they may gravitate toward another firm before you have a chance to address their concerns.
- ~ By bringing up such potential problems right away, you also demonstrate a broad appreciation of the issue and imply confidence in your message.
- ~ This anticipation is particularly important when you're not delivering a message in person and won't have the opportunity to detect and respond to objections on the spot.
- ~ To uncover potential audience objections, try to poke holes in your own theories and ideas before your audience does.

Avoiding Common Mistakes

When you believe in a concept or project you are promoting, it's easy to get caught up in your own confidence and enthusiasm and thereby fail to see things from the audience's perspective. **When putting together persuasive arguments, avoid these common mistakes:**

- **Using a hard sell.** Don't push. No one likes being pressured into making a decision, and communicators who take this approach can come across as being more concerned with meeting their own goals than with satisfying the needs of their audiences. In contrast, a "soft sell" is more like a comfortable conversation that uses calm, rational persuasion.
- **Resisting compromise.** Successful persuasion is often a process of give-and-take, particularly in the case of persuasive business messages, where you don't always get everything, you asked for in terms of budgets, investments, and other commitments.
- **Relying solely on great arguments.** Great arguments are important but connecting with your audience on the right emotional level and communicating through vivid language are just as vital. Sometimes a well-crafted story can be even more compelling than dry logic.
- **Assuming that persuasion is a one-shot effort.** Persuasion is often a process, not a one-time event. In many cases you need to move your audience members along one small step at a time rather than try to convince them to say "yes" in one huge step.

THE END.

